

Meta-Fracas

YOU'VE NO DOUBT HEARD, AS HAS THE REST OF THE WORLD, ABOUT THE METAVERSE

— the massive undertaking by Facebook (henceforth, Meta) to recreate a digital twin of everyone and everything. The most relatable examples are those of Second-Life and the virtual world that has everyone hooked in WALL-E. And for folks who're a little older, The Matrix is a more dystopian take on the whole thing.

We've all known that this was going to happen anyways. Aside from the countless movies and written works of fiction that have predicted the Metaverse, there was always the fact that technology was going to find its way into every aspect of our lives before we finally become one with it. Just over the last two decades, we've allowed "smart" objects to slowly creep into our lives. We've allowed smartphones, smart watches, smart home appliances, smart gizmos and many more IoT devices into our lives, and we've willingly allowed the companies that made these devices to collect data about ourselves in lieu of providing better services. When you look at each individual transaction along the way, it always felt as if the transaction was fair. You'd let them track your location so that you could get to the destination quicker. They then learnt about your commonly visited spots. They then distinguished from amongst the commonly visited spots, your home, your college and your office. They then provided you with intelligent updates regarding your commute in advance, so that you could avoid that nasty traffic jam along the route to work. After that, they ensured that your air-conditioner would switch on a few minutes before you made it to the office or your home so that you'd be welcomed by a comfortable atmosphere.

Bit-by-bit, piece-by-piece, they learnt about you. Each service only learnt about one facet of your persona. And when services could leverage simple APIs to talk to each other, all those little pieces came together to create your digital avatar. Machines with powerful algorithms are now capable of predicting your actions with a relatively good measure of accuracy. So it was only a matter of time before some company decided to make you into a product and sell it back to

you. Sucker... Until now, they were selling you (in effect, your data) to other marketing companies which would then leverage that data to sell you goods. Now that they've got something better to sell.

The Metaverse isn't a new concept that Meta introduced to the world. The Enterprise Technology space has been using similar technologies on the factory floor for a couple of years now. Primarily because only manufacturing companies would spend the ridiculous monies required to set up and run such virtual spaces. Meta's ambitious plans would require that it democratise the technology for content creators and lower the entry barrier for users to hop onto the platform. However, Meta isn't the only company working on a Metaverse solution. Microsoft recently announced plans similar to what Meta did. Companies such as Unity have created so many assets that are being used to create virtual worlds that they became some of the biggest players in the space overnight. Then there are the technology enablers i.e. folks such as Autodesk and NVIDIA, who are either developing the hardware or the software or both.

Naturally, every company wants to own the largest slice of the pie and the fight now will be about that. Meta has the natural advantage here, it designs processors for its data centres and then implements said processors in data centres across the globe. It even designs and sells the VR headsets required to experience the Metaverse in its truest form. And most importantly, it owns your digital avatar and therefore, it can create experiences that none of the other companies can ever hope to match up to.

We might as well just crown Meta the victor and be done with it. However, we all know that Facebook (Meta) has a massive image problem. An image problem that's perceived by you and me, but you and I don't log on to Facebook that often. At least, not anymore. It's the millions of new users who've only discovered the Internet over the last four or five years that are going to form the largest chunk of Metaverse's users over time. And they don't care about Meta's image problem. So now, who do you think will own the Metaverse finally? Meta or is there another player in the game? **d**



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